

German Verb Suffixes & Prefixes

The definitive guide to German verb formation: Inseparable Prefixes (**Untrennbare Präfixe**), Separable Prefixes (**Trennbare Präfixe**), Dual/Variable Prefixes (**Wechselpräfixe**), and Verb-forming Suffixes with semantic functions, stress rules, and high-frequency vocabulary.

Core Verb Prefix Principles:

- **Inseparable (be-, emp-, ent-, er-, ge-, miss-, ver-, zer-):** The prefix is unstressed, stays attached in all tenses, and does not take *ge-* in Partizip II (*verstehen* → *verstand* → *hat verstanden*).
- **Separable (ab-, an-, auf-, aus-, ein-, mit-, zu-...):** The prefix carries the main stress, splits off to the end in main clauses (*Ich stehe auf*), and takes *-ge-* in the middle of Partizip II (*aufgestanden*).
- **Dual Prefixes (durch-, über-, um-, unter-, wider-, wieder-):** Literal motion = Separable; Figurative/Abstract = Inseparable.

The Mnemonic for Inseparable Prefixes:

'Be-emp-ent-er, ge-miss-ver-zer lassen das ge- weg!'

Verb Suffixes (Verbsuffixe):

- **-ieren:** Creates regular verbs from Latin/French roots (*studieren, reparieren*). No *ge-* in Partizip II (*studiert*).
- **-eln:** Diminutive / frequentative (*lächeln* = to smile gently, *tänzel* = to prance).
- **-ern:** Frequentative / iterative (*flüstern* = to whisper, *glitzern* = to sparkle).
- **-igen:** Derives causative verbs from adjectives/nouns (*reinigen* = to clean, *festigen*).

1. Inseparable Verb Prefixes (Untrennbare Präfixe — Unstressed, No 'ge-' in Partizip II)

Präfix	Semantic Meaning & Function	High-Frequency Examples & Meanings
be-	Makes intransitive verbs transitive (adds direct object); covers with; provides with	bezahlen (to pay for), beantworten (to answer), besuchen (to visit), beschreiben (to describe), bekommen (to receive), behandeln (to treat), beraten (to advise)
emp-	Sensory perception, reception (historic variant of ent- before f)	empfangen (to receive/welcome), empfehlen (to recommend), empfinden (to feel/sense)
ent-	Removal, separation, escaping, origin/beginning, reversal ('un-')	entdecken (to discover), entscheiden (to decide), entstehen (to arise/originate), entkommen (to escape), entfernen (to remove), entlassen (to dismiss/fire), entschuldigen (to excuse)
er-	Achievement through effort, reaching a goal, fatal end, beginning a state	erreichen (to achieve/reach), erfahren (to find out/experience), erfinden (to invent), erinnern (to remind), erkennen (to recognize), erklären (to explain), ertrinken (to drown)
ge-	Completion, collective result, successful attainment	gewinnen (to win), gefallen (to please), gehören (to belong to), gelingen (to succeed), geschehen (to happen), gebrauchen (to make use of)
miss-	Failure, incorrectness, error, negative intent (English 'mis- / dis-')	misstrauen (to distrust), missverstehen (to misunderstand), misslingen (to fail), missbrauchen (to abuse), missachten (to disregard)
ver-	1. Error/mistake ('verrechnen') 2. Change of state ('verändern') 3. Disappearance/loss ('verlieren') 4. Intense completion ('verbrauchen')	verstehen (to understand), verkaufen (to sell), verlieren (to lose), vergessen (to forget), verändern (to change), verbessern (to improve), verreisen (to travel away), versprechen (to promise/misspeak)
zer-	Destruction, breaking into pieces, tearing apart, dissolving completely	zerstören (to destroy), zerbrechen (to shatter/break to pieces), zerreißen (to tear up), zerstören (to wreck), zerkleinern (to chop up), zerfallen (to disintegrate)

2. Top Separable Verb Prefixes (Trennbare Präfixe — Stressed, Splits in Present/Past)

Präfix	Semantic Meaning & Function	High-Frequency Examples & Meanings
ab-	Separation, downward movement, reduction, completion, departure	abfahren (to depart), abholen (to pick up), absagen (to cancel), abnehmen (to lose weight/decrease), abschließen (to lock/finish)
an-	Contact, beginning, approaching, turning on (devices), attachment	ankommen (to arrive), anrufen (to call), anfangen (to begin), anschalten (to turn on), anziehen (to put on clothes), anbieten (to offer)
auf-	Upward motion, opening, sudden emergence, terminating, waking up	aufstehen (to stand up), aufmachen (to open), aufhören (to stop), aufpassen (to pay attention), aufräumen (to tidy up)
aus-	Outward motion, exit, turning off (lights), completion, expanding	ausgehen (to go out), ausmachen (to turn off), aussteigen (to get off), aussehen (to look/appear), ausfüllen (to fill out)
ein-	Inward motion, entering, falling asleep, initiating, packing	einkaufen (to shop), einladen (to invite), einsteigen (to get on), einschlafen (to fall asleep), einpacken (to pack up)
mit-	Togetherness, participation, accompaniment, bringing along	mitkommen (to come along), mitbringen (to bring along), mitmachen (to participate), mitnehmen (to take with)
nach-	Following, repetition, imitation, delayed action, checking	nachdenken (to reflect/ponder), nachmachen (to imitate), nachschlagen (to look up), nachfragen (to inquire)
vor-	Forward motion, performing in front of, preparation, preference	vorbereiten (to prepare), vorstellen (to introduce/imagine), vorhaben (to plan/intend), vorschlagen (to suggest)
zu-	Towards, closing/shutting, addition, increase, agreeing	zumachen (to close), zuhören (to listen to), zunehmen (to gain weight/increase), zustimmen (to agree)
zurück-	Returning, backward motion, reversibility	zurückkommen (to come back), zurückgeben (to give back), zurückrufen (to call back), zurückkehren (to return)
zusammen-	Together, union, collision, collapsing	zusammenarbeiten (to collaborate), zusammenbrechen (to collapse), zusammenfassen (to summarize)

3. Dual / Variable Prefixes (Wechselpräfixe — Literal vs. Figurative)

Dual prefixes can be either **separable** (stressed = literal, physical motion) or **inseparable** (unstressed = figurative, abstract, transformative).

Präfix	Separable Usage (Literal / Physical)	Inseparable Usage (Figurative / Abstract)
durch-	TRENNBAR (Literal motion through): <i>durchschneiden</i> (to cut through), <i>durchfallen</i> (to fall through) <i>Er schneidet das Seil <u>durch</u>.</i>	UNTRENNBAR (Abstract / complete thoroughness): <i>durchsuchen</i> (to search thoroughly), <i>durchqueren</i> (to cross) <i>Die Polizei <u>durchsucht</u> das Haus.</i>
über-	TRENNBAR (Literal over / crossing over): <i>überkochen</i> (to boil over), <i>übergehen</i> (to pass over/spill) <i>Die Milch kocht <u>über</u>.</i>	UNTRENNBAR (Abstract / transfer / translation / exceeding): <i>übersetzen</i> (to translate), <i>überraschen</i> (to surprise), <i>übertreiben</i> (to exaggerate) <i>Er <u>übersetzt</u> den Roman.</i>
um-	TRENNBAR (Change / falling over / turnaround): <i>umziehen</i> (to relocate), <i>umfallen</i> (to fall over), <i>umsteigen</i> (to transfer trains) <i>Ich ziehe morgen <u>um</u>.</i>	UNTRENNBAR (Surrounding / enclosing / bypassing): <i>umarmen</i> (to hug/embrace), <i>umkreisen</i> (to orbit), <i>umgeben</i> (to surround) <i>Sie <u>umarmt</u> ihre Mutter.</i>
unter-	TRENNBAR (Literal downward motion): <i>untergehen</i> (to sink/set), <i>untertauchen</i> (to submerge) <i>Die Sonne geht <u>unter</u>.</i>	UNTRENNBAR (Abstract / suppression / signing / interruption): <i>unterschreiben</i> (to sign), <i>unterrichten</i> (to teach), <i>untersuchen</i> (to examine) <i>Ich <u>unterschreibe</u> den Vertrag.</i>
wieder-	TRENNBAR (Back again / return): <i>wiedersehen</i> (to see again), <i>wiederholen</i> (to bring back) <i>Wir sehen uns bald <u>wieder</u>!</i>	UNTRENNBAR (Repetition / review): <i>wiederholen</i> (to repeat/revise words/lessons) <i>Bitte <u>wiederholen</u> Sie den Satz!</i>

4. Verb-Forming Suffixes (Verbsuffixe — Suffix-basierte Verbbildung)

German creates new verbs using specific derivational suffixes with distinct semantic patterns and conjugational rules.

Suffix	Function & Linguistic Origin	Examples & Semantic Shifts
-ieren	Forms verbs from French/Latin loan roots (Always weak, regular; Partizip II in -iert without ge-)	<i>studieren</i> → <i>studiert</i> (to study), <i>reparieren</i> → <i>repariert</i> (to repair), <i>funktionieren</i> (to work), <i>interessieren</i> (to interest), <i>telefonieren</i> (to phone), <i>reservieren</i> (to book)
-eln	Diminutive (makes actions smaller/cuter) or frequentative (repetitive/light action)	<i>lächeln</i> (to smile — from <i>lachen</i>), <i>tänzeln</i> (to prance — from <i>tanzen</i>), <i>kränkeln</i> (to be sickly — from <i>krank</i>), <i>streicheln</i> (to pet/stroke), <i>basteln</i> (to do crafts)
-ern	Iterative / frequentative (continuous minor sounds or movements)	<i>flüstern</i> (to whisper), <i>glitzern</i> (to sparkle), <i>zittern</i> (to shiver/tremble), <i>klettern</i> (to climb), <i>wandern</i> (to hike), <i>ändern</i> (to change — from <i>anders</i>)
-igen	Causative: Derives active verbs from adjectives or nouns ('to make X')	<i>reinigen</i> (to clean — from <i>rein</i>), <i>beruhigen</i> (to calm — from <i>ruhig</i>), <i>bestätigen</i> (to confirm — from <i>stet</i>), <i>entschuldigen</i> (to excuse), <i>kündigen</i> (to resign/terminate)
-isieren	Denotes systemic transformation, modernizing, or ideological process (Latin -isare)	<i>modernisieren</i> (to modernize), <i>organisieren</i> (to organize), <i>globalisieren</i> (to globalize), <i>harmonisieren</i> (to harmonize), <i>kritisieren</i> (to criticize)
-ifizieren	Denotes making or qualifying into a standard state (Latin -ificare)	<i>qualifizieren</i> (to qualify), <i>identifizieren</i> (to identify), <i>modifizieren</i> (to modify), <i>verifizieren</i> (to verify)